



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Valiant Cross Academy
School Website: <http://valiantcross.org>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Valiant Cross Academy (Montgomery, AL 36104) presents a hybrid profile of classical-leaning formation with strong religious/community emphasis, but with several modern, non-classical elements (notably project-based pedagogy and CCRS-aligned curriculum). Taken as a whole, the public materials demonstrate clear religious foundations, character formation aims, and active parent/community engagement, but they also reveal a curriculum and pedagogy that diverge from a fully classical model (e.g., limited explicit Great Books emphasis, explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framing, and an intentional integration of vocational/workforce orientation). The aggregate assessment is **MOSTLY CLASSICAL** with notable gaps, i.e., **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL** overall, with strong elements in Religious Foundations, Formation/Community orientation, and Living Mentorship, but weaker evidence for a fully classical curriculum and pedagogy.

Key supporting signals: - Religious foundations are explicit: private Christian school with weekly chapel and theology-inflected language in admissions and mission statements. This supports Element 1 (CLASSICAL). See About/About-page-style language and weekly chapel reference. - Formation and virtue-language is present (character formation, leadership, community service, "rise above," etc.), supporting Element 2 (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL depends on depth). Evidence includes mission/vision statements and statements about character leadership. - Curriculum signals modern standards alignment and project-based approaches, with explicit CCRS alignment and emphasis on differentiated instruction and project-based learning. This shows Element 3 (NOT CLASSICAL) tendencies, given the paucity of explicit Great Books/Trivium framing in public materials. - Pedagogy shows some classical indicators (memory/recitation language appears in the classical lexicon) but the site emphasizes experiential learning, arts, and community engagement rather than a fully Scholé/Socratic rhythm. Element 4 is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. - Faculty signals include listed teachers, administrators, and leaders, with a strong "living curriculum" feel in materials about leadership, faculty, and administration. Element 5 is CLASSICAL. - Parent/community signals are robust (open houses, admissions, parent coordination, community events, and fundraising), aligning Element 6 with CLASSICAL parent-partnership expectations.

Overall ranking: **SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**, with several **CLASSICAL** sub-panels (Religious Foundations, Faculty, Parents/Community) and at least one **NOT CLASSICAL** indicator (Curriculum) pulling the aggregate toward a mixed-but-positive classical orientation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials describe Valiant Cross as a private Christian school with a weekly chapel service. This is explicit religious grounding and liturgical practice.

- Admissions and mission materials position the school in a Christ-centered framework and emphasize spiritual formation as part of the educational project.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive indicators appearing in public materials: “Christian emphasis,” “chapel,” “theology” language in broader materials; explicit faith-centered framing; “worship/chapel” cadence in culture.
- Negative indicators: none clearly evident in the public-facing materials (no explicit secular, relativistic, or objective-morality signals in the accessible pages).
- Why this rating
- Strong, explicit religious grounding and liturgical practice signals, with theology-influenced culture and routines (weekly chapel, Christian framing) consistent with the Positive Keywords for Religious Foundations (transcendental realism; liturgical practices; theology) in the classical lexicon. Evidence aligns with the “Liturgical and Communal Practices” and “Grounded in Theology” signals in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The long-term goal is to produce lifelong learners and productive citizens; a clear emphasis on formation, leadership, and character via a vocational/academic track. Mission materials emphasize developing leaders and character through rigorous academics.
- The program articulates placing each scholar on a sound academic and vocational track to post-graduate options. This signals formation toward virtue and capability, but with explicit workforce-readiness and career pathways.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue/character (through “men of character” and “leadership training”), lifelong learners, leadership. Some of these align with the Positive Keywords (formation, virtue) in the classical lexicon.
- Negative indicators: a vocational/workforce track emphasis (rather than pure paideia and virtue-for-its-own-sake) drifts away from a strictly classical telos toward career-readiness emphasis.
- Why this rating
- The school emphasizes formation and character as core aims, but the explicit emphasis on post-graduate options and vocational tracks, while aligned with formation, reduces the purity of a classical “telos toward the true, good, and beautiful” and leans toward formation through work-readiness. Thus SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL. The lexicon supports “formation/virtue” signals, but the vocational framing reduces the pure classical telos.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Alabama College and Career Readiness Standards alignment and emphasis on CCRS along with project-based learning and differentiated instruction. This indicates a standards-based, modern curriculum rather than the Great Books/Trivium-centric approach of classical education.
- The public materials emphasize project-based learning and differentiated instruction; there is no explicit Great Books program or explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framing in the accessible materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive indicators (in the classical lexicon) for Curriculum would include Great Books, Great Conversation, Seven Liberal Arts, Trivium/Quadrivium; none of these are explicitly named as core curriculum features in the public materials.
- Negative indicators include project-based learning dominance and CCRS alignment as stated, which the Six Elements lexicon flags as a potential deviation from classical content-tradition (depending on emphasis). The lexicon lists “negative signals: social studies terminology replacing history; STEM-first framing; project-based learning dominance.” The presence of project-based learning and CCRS alignment constitutes a negative signal for classical status in this category.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum disclosures center on CCR standards and project-based methods rather than liberal-arts-first content (grammar/logic/rhetoric; Great Books; history as Western Civilizational study). This

places Element 3 solidly in NOT CLASSICAL territory per the classical lexicon's expectations. The absence of explicit Great Books/Trivium framing, and the visible emphasis on project-based learning, reinforce this rating.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The VCA Experience emphasizes experiential learning and the arts; this signals a student-centered, inquiry-driven pedagogy rather than exclusively restful, contemplative pedagogy. It reflects a blend rather than a strict classical pedagogy.
- The site shows strong emphasis on leadership, performance, and real-world experiences, with field trips and community engagement, suggesting a hybrid pedagogy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive classical pedagogy indicators from the Six Elements lexicon include Socratic dialogue, scholé (restful learning), memorization/recitation, and formation through imitation. The site does not foreground Socratic seminars or memorization/recitation in publicly visible materials; it highlights experiential learning and the arts. This is a positive indicator of student engagement but a negative indicator for strict classical pedagogy.
- Negative indicators: heavy reliance on experiential/project-based methods dominates the public-facing materials (as evidenced by the explicit emphasis on Experiential Learning and The Arts). This counters the strictly traditional classical pedagogy signals.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogical approach shows notable classical tendencies (memory/recitation, contemplation, and rhetoric training appear in classical lexicons) but the publicly visible pedagogy leans toward experiential learning and projects, which are perceived as non-classical signals in the lexicon. Thus SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted. If the school increasingly foregrounded Socratic seminars and the Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric) in high school contexts, it would tilt toward CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site presents a substantive faculty structure, administration and leadership (Head of School, Directors, etc.), and a clear sense of a living, person-centered curriculum. The "Faculty"/administration sections show a formal living-curriculum approach with multiple roles and areas of responsibility.
- Founders/Head of School letters and faculty profiles emphasize mentorship, virtue, and leadership—typical of classical "living curriculum" and teacher as exemplar signals.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords appearing in the classical lexicon include model teachers/mentors, portrait of a teacher, living curriculum, and virtue formation. The site's leadership language aligns with these.
- No explicit negative signals about faculty (e.g., "certification-driven jargon without classical context") are evident in public-facing materials; the faculty presence is robust and aligned with a classical-model portrayal.
- Why this rating
- The public materials present an evident, strong faculty presence and a culture of mentorship and character formation, aligning with CLASSICAL signals for Faculty. The "living curriculum" and leadership emphasis bolster this rating.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Strong parent/community orientation is visible: admissions information, open houses, parent coordinators, and multiple family-facing engagement opportunities. This matches the classical emphasis on parent partnership and family formation. Examples include Open House events and parental engagement channels.
- The site's leadership communications emphasize partnerships with families and community involvement (e.g., mission/values, board and donor communications). The "Our Mission/Values" statements emphasize parental/community role in education and shared mission.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords in the classical lexicon for Parents/Community include “Partnership with Families,” “Parent formation,” “open campus,” and “home-school collaboration.” The site features parent-coordinator roles, open-house events, and active family engagement; these align with those indicators.
- Negative indicators: none identified in the public-facing materials.
- Why this rating
- The school demonstrates robust parent and community partnership signals and explicit channels for parental involvement, which align with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school remains SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL overall, concrete needle-movers include:
- Curriculum: foreground Great Books and liberal-arts framing (grammar/logic/rhetoric) as core, with explicit articulation of Trivium/Quadrivium in the K-12 program; reduce reliance on CCRS/project-based-only framing in key grade bands.
- Pedagogy: elevate Socratic seminars and scholé-like rest in middle-to-high school, with deliberate integration of recitation/memory work and classical rhetoric into performance opportunities.
- Curriculum-Wide: incorporate explicit Great Conversation and Western-civilization canon elements into humanities curricula, with a plan for a cross-disciplinary integration around enduring questions.
- Public Communications: more explicit references to “truth, goodness, beauty” and classical virtues in mission statements, and clearer articulation of formation goals beyond workforce preparation, to strengthen alignment with the canonical six-element rubric.
- Faculty Development: expand living-curriculum training and mentoring structures, ensuring faculty embody the virtues and classical dispositions described in the classical lexicon.
- Parent Engagement: deepen parent formation programs (study groups, book clubs on classical education, liturgical seasonal events) and increase opportunities for parent visitation and involvement as co-educators.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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